abbātem), *abbot*; **assa**, *donkey*; **catte** (OHG. **kazza**), *cat*; **cassuc**, *sedge*; **gaffetung**, *scoffing*; **habban** (§ **538**), *to have*; **hassuc**, *coarse grass*; **maffa**, *caul*; **mattoc**, *mattock*; **sacc**, *sack*; **þaccian**, *to flap, pat*; **flasce** (**flaxe**), *flask*; **masc** (**max**), *net*; **wascan** (**waxan**), *to wash*; **brastlian**, *to crackle*. But a few words have **æ** beside **a**, as **æsce**, *ash, cinders*; **æppel**, *apple*; **hnæppian**, *to doze*; **læppa**, *lappet*, beside **asce** (**axe**), **appla**, *apples*, **hnappian**, **lappa**.

NOTE.—**sca-** was often written **scea-** with **e** to denote the palatal pronunciation of the **sc**, as **sceacan**, *to shake*; **sceadu**, *shadow*; **sceafan**, *to shave*; **scealu**, *scale* (*balance*); **sceamu** (**sceomu**, § **59**), *shame*, beside **scacan**, **scadu**, **scafan**, **scalu**, **scamu** (**scomu**). See § **51**, Note.

§ **58**. **a** became **æ** when followed by an umlauted vowel in the next syllable, as **æces** (**æx**) from ***akysi**, older ***akusi-**, *axe*; and similarly **æþele** from ***aþali** (OS. **ađali**), *noble*; **æþeling** from ***aþuling**, *nobleman*; **æt-**, **tō-gædere** from ***-gađuri**, *together*; **fæsten** (OS. **fastunnia**, *fasting*), *fortress*; **gædeling** (OS. **gaduling**), *companion*; **hæleþ** from ***χaluþi-**, *hero*; **hærfest** from ***χaruþist**, *harvest*; **mægden** from ***magađīn** (OHG. **magatīn**), *maiden*. The **æ** in the above examples is a kind of umlaut.

NOTE.—The **a** in the stem-syllable of the present participle and gerund of strong verbs belonging to class VI (§ **508**) is due to the **a** of the infinitive, as **farende** for ***færende** from ***farandi**, **farenne** for ***færenne** from ***farannjai**.

§ **59**. Germanic **a** was probably a mid-back-wide vowel like the **a** in German **Mann**. In OE. it became a low-back-wide vowel before nasals like the **â** in French **pâte**, and the **a** as pronounced in many Scotch dialects in such words as **ant**, **man**, **pass**, which English people often mistake for **o** especially when lengthened. In the oldest OE. it was nearly always written **a**, in the ninth century it was mostly written **o**, and in late OE. mostly **a** again, but